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Exploring health outcomes and care experiences of adults with post-COVID-19 condition in Belgium

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Background: Post-COVID-19 condition (PCC) and its multisystemic effects have a profound impact on health systems. However, limited insight exist into PCC patients' perspectives, perceived health outcomes and care experiences in Belgium.

Methods: OECD's Patient-Reported Indicator Surveys (PaRIS) collected patient-reported outcome (PROMs) and experience measures (PREMs) among people aged 45+ with chronic conditions. In Belgium, self-reported data was gathered from 4687 primary care patients between March 2023-January 2024. This study explores care outcomes and experiences of adults with PCC in Belgium, by comparing respondents with and without PCC. After adjusting for age and sex, descriptive and logistic regression analyses were conducted. Heatmaps for 10 key indicators (PARIS10), adjusted for age, sex, number of chronic conditions were also developed.

Results: Among study participants, 52% were women, 56% aged 45-64, 42% had higher education and 20% had no chronic condition. Overall, 50% (N = 2359) had a previous COVID-19 diagnosis, and over one in four (26%) of them reported PCC-related symptoms lasting 2 months or longer after COVID-19 infection (N = 605, 12.9% overall prevalence). Higher risk of PCC was associated with being female, aged 45-54, having multiple chronic conditions, higher BMI, and lower education. PCC patients reported significant lower PROM scores for general health, wellbeing, physical and mental health compared to non-PCC respondents. Those with symptoms lasting at least 1 year reported even poorer outcomes, particularly in general health, wellbeing and physical health. PREMs showed no significant differences between PCC and non-PCC respondents overall. However, trust in healthcare system and person-centred care was significant lower when PCC patients still had these long-term symptoms at survey time.

Conclusions: In Belgium, adult patients in primary care with PCC report poorer health outcomes and less positive care experiences compared to those without PCC.

Key messages:

- In Belgium, among primary care patients aged 45+ who have been infected with COVID-19, 26% report persistent (≥ 2 months) PCC-related symptoms, corresponding to an overall prevalence of 12.9%.
- Patient-reported indicators show substantial differences in care between PCC and non-PCC patients in Belgium, underscoring the importance of adequate follow-up and support by healthcare professionals.